

Contraception

prc-contraception

Marriage & Sexuality · Family Planning · practice · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts
Reached by general principle, not by a naming word
No NT manuscript apparatus applies

Statement under examination

Non-abortifacient contraception is a matter of Christian liberty; abortifacient methods (those that prevent implantation of a fertilized egg) are inconsistent with sanctity-of-life ethics.

In plain language

This statement makes two claims at once. The first is that birth control which only prevents conception is a matter of personal freedom for a married couple. The second is that any method which acts after an egg is fertilized clashes with the high value the Bible places on human life. The Hebrew and Greek texts speak warmly about having children but never name birth control. In Genesis 1 God blesses the first couple and tells them to 'be fruitful and multiply' (parah and rabah, פָּרָה וְרָבָה) and fill the earth. That same word pair, 'be fruitful and multiply', shows up fifteen times in the Old Testament, and every single time it is spoken over a whole group: humanity, Noah's family, a patriarch's line, the people of Israel. It is never a quota for one marriage. Psalm 127 calls sons a 'heritage' (nachalah, נַחְלָה) from the LORD and the fruit of the womb a 'reward' (sakar, שָׂכָר), like arrows in a warrior's hand, and blesses the man whose quiver is full. These praise children as a gift, but praising one good outcome is not the same as forbidding any other arrangement. The one passage often pulled into this discussion is Genesis 38, where Onan spills his seed and God puts him to death. The Hebrew there matters: in the verse just before, Judah uses the verb 'perform the levirate duty' (yabam, יָבַם), the technical term for the brother-in-law duty to raise up children for a dead brother. That verb shows up only three times in the whole Bible. So when Onan acts, the text immediately ties his offense to refusing that very duty, not to any general teaching about how married couples may or may not conceive. As for the second half of the claim, Psalm 139 says God 'acquires' (qanah, קָנָה) and weaves a person inside the 'womb' (rechem, רֶחֶם), and Jeremiah 1 says God 'knew' (yada, יָדַע) the prophet before forming him there. Those texts attach God's personal action to the unborn, which gives real lexical ground for treating the destruction of a fertilized embryo as the same kind of wrong the Bible calls the destruction of life. The bottom line is that the words leave the method question genuinely open while supplying a strong scriptural footing for the sanctity-of-life concern, so honest readers can land on either side of the first claim, and the verdict is recorded as disputed at low confidence rather than as settled either way.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0835	אֵשֶׁר	esher	blessed	37
H1288	בָּרַךְ	barak	to bless	305
H1368	גִּבּוֹר	gibbor	mighty man	
H2671	חֵץ	chets	arrow	
H2992	יָבַם	yabam	be brother-in-law	3
H3045	יָדַע	yada	to know	

H3206	יָלַד	yeled	youth	
H4191	מוֹת	mut	to die	
H4390	מָלֵא	male	to fill	235
H5159	נַחֲלָה	nachalah	inheritance	218
H6509	פָּרָה	parah	be fruitful	28
H6529	פֵּרִי	peri	fruit	114
H7069	קָנָה	qanah	to buy	
H7235	רָבָה	rabah	to multiply	204
H7358	רֶחֶם	rechem	womb	
H7489	רָעָע	ra'a'	be evil	93
H7843	שָׁחַת	shachat	to ruin	143
H7939	שָׂכָר	sakar	wages	26
G0591	ἀποδίδωμι	apodidōmi	to pay	
G0650	ἀποστερέω	apostereo	to defraud	6
G2133	εὐνοία	eunoia	enthusiasm	
G3782	ὀφειλή	opheile	debt	3
G4859	σύμφωνος	sumphōnos	mutual consent	

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The lexicon names neither contraception nor the medical line the proposition draws between non-abortifacient and abortifacient methods. The creation blessing in Genesis 1:28 issues the imperatives 'be fruitful and multiply' (pe'ru u'revu, פְּרוּ וּרְבוּ) coupled with 'subdue' (kavash, כָּבַשׁ) and 'rule' (radah, רָדָה), and Psalm 127:3 to 5 calls sons a 'heritage' (nachalah, נַחֲלָה) and 'reward' (sakar, שָׂכָר) and blesses the man who has 'filled' (mi'le, מָלֵא) his quiver, weighting children as a corporate good without speaking to per-couple management of conception. Crucially the verb pair 'be fruitful' (parah, פָּרָה) plus 'multiply' (rabah, רָבָה) occurs together in 15 verses across the canon and every instance is corporate, spoken over humanity, Noah, the patriarchs, or Israel, never as a per-marriage quota. The single proof text often cited is Genesis 38:9 to 10 (Onan), but Genesis 38:8 has Judah command Onan with the verb 'perform the levirate duty' (yabam, יָבַם), a lemma (dictionary form of a word) found only 3 times in the canon (Genesis 38:8, Deuteronomy 25:5, Deuteronomy 25:7), so the Hebrew immediately frames the offense as refusal of a culturally specific brother's duty, not as a free-standing condemnation of any seed-non-fertilization act. On the abortifacient half of the claim the womb-formation texts (Psalm 139:13 with H7069 'acquire' (qanah, קָנָה) and H7358 'womb' (rechem, רֶחֶם), Jeremiah 1:5) lexically attach personal divine action to the unborn, which supplies a real (though not direct) ground for treating destruction of an implanted or implanting embryo as falling under the sanctity-of-life prohibitions even though contraception as a category is unnamed.

Scripture

Gen.1.28 · neutral · genre: narrative · figures: merism

Key terms. H6509 פָּרָה, H7235A רָבָה, H1288 בָּרַךְ, H4390 מָלָא

Reasoning. God 'blesses' (vayvarekh, וַיְבָרֶךְ) the man and woman and issues the imperatives 'be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth and subdue it' (pe'ru u'revu u'mil'u et ha'aretz ve'kivshuha, פְּרוּ וּרְבוּ וּמָלְאוּ אֶת הָאָרֶץ וְכִבְשׁוּהָ). The verbs 'be fruitful' (parah, 28, פָּרָה, times in canon) and 'multiply' (rabah, 204, רָבָה, times) are imperatives of increase set inside a creation blessing addressed to humanity as a species. The same pair recurs at Genesis 8:17, 9:1, 9:7, 17:20, 28:3, 35:11, 47:27, 48:4, Exodus 1:7, Leviticus 26:9, Jeremiah 3:16, 23:3, Ezekiel 36:11, and always as a corporate increase formula spoken over humanity, Noah, a patriarch, or a covenant people, not as a quota for an individual marriage.

Gen.9.7 · neutral · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6509 פָּרָה, H7235A רָבָה

Reasoning. 'Be fruitful and multiply, swarm in the earth and multiply in it' (pe'ru u'revu shirtzu va'aretz u'revu vah, פְּרוּ וּרְבוּ וּשְׂרָצוּ בָאָרֶץ וּרְבוּ בָהּ). The post-flood renewal repeats the creation pair 'be fruitful' (parah, פָּרָה) and 'multiply' (rabah, רָבָה), again addressed to Noah and his sons as the regenerating human stock, which lexically reinforces the corporate, demographic scope of the imperative pair.

Ps.127.3 · neutral · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H5159 נָתַלָה, H6529 פָּרִי, H7939 שָׂכָר

Reasoning. Sons are a 'heritage, allotted inheritance' (nachalah, נַחְלָה) of the LORD and the 'fruit of the womb' (peri ha'beten, פְּרִי הַבֶּטֶן) is a 'reward, wages, payment' (sakar, שָׂכָר). Both nouns frame children as gift granted and recompense given, weighing offspring as blessing rather than burden. The verse states a valuation, not a directive about whether conception may be planned or limited.

Ps.127.4 · neutral · genre: wisdom · figures: simile

Key terms. H2671 חֶץ, H1368 גִּבּוֹר

Reasoning. Like 'arrows' (ke'chitzim, כְּחִצִּים) in the hand of a 'mighty man' (gibbor, גִּבּוֹר), so are the sons of one's youth. The simile likens children to a warrior's arrows, an image of strength and ancestral honor in an agonistic culture (a culture organized around competitive struggle), but a commendation of an outcome is not a prohibition of any other arrangement.

Ps.127.5 · neutral · genre: wisdom · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H0835 אָשֵׁר, H4390 מָלָא

Reasoning. 'Blessed' (ashrei, אֲשֵׁרִי) is the man who has 'filled' (mi'le, מָלָא) his 'quiver' (ashpah, אֲשָׁפָה) with them. The beatitude (a 'blessed is...' saying) commends the man with many sons in the city gate, a hortatory (encouraging, urging) wisdom blessing on fullness of quiver. A wisdom beatitude on one positive outcome is not a binding command against any alternative outcome.

Gen.38.8 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H2992 יָבַם

Reasoning. Judah commands Onan, 'Go in to your brother's wife and perform the duty of a brother-in-law to her' (ve'yabbem otah, וַיַּבֵּם אֹתָהּ), and raise up offspring for your brother. The Piel (the Hebrew intensive form) of 'perform the levirate duty' (yabam, יָבַם) is a hapax-tight (occurring extremely rarely) technical levirate verb (a verb tied to the brother-in-law marriage law). The lemma (dictionary form) occurs only 3 times in the canon (here, Deuteronomy 25:5, Deuteronomy 25:7) and exclusively names the brother-in-law's obligation to sire seed for a dead brother. The immediate context of Genesis 38:9 is therefore lexically locked to the levirate institution before the spilling-of-seed clause is reached.

Gen.38.9 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H7843 שחַח, H3045 יָדַע.

Reasoning. Onan 'knew' (yada, יָדַע) that the offspring would not be his, so whenever he went in to his brother's wife, he 'destroyed (it on the ground)' (ve'shichet artzah, וְשִׁחַת אֶרֶצָה) to keep from giving offspring to his brother. The Piel (the Hebrew intensive form) of 'destroy' (shachat, שָׁחַת) is a generic 'ruin' or 'destroy' verb (143 times in canon) used of corrupting flesh, ruining a vineyard, wasting a city. The motive clause 'so as not to give seed to his brother' (le'vilti naton zera le'achiv, לְבִלְתִּי נָתַן זֶרַע לְאָחִיו) makes the levirate refusal the explicit purpose of the act, so the Hebrew binds physical act and refused duty into one composite offense rather than isolating the physical act.

Gen.38.10 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H7489A רָעַע, H4191 מוֹת

Reasoning. What he did 'was evil' (va'yera, וַיֵּרָע) in the eyes of the LORD, and 'he put him to death' (va'yamet, וַיָּמָת) also. The judgment clause names divine displeasure but the antecedent (the prior phrase it refers back to) of 'what he did' (asher asah, אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה) is the whole action of verse 9, including its stated motive, so the lexicon does not isolate which constituent (the seed-wasting in isolation, the levirate refusal, or both) is the object of the displeasure.

Deut.25.5 · complicates · genre: law

Key terms. H2992 יָבַם

Reasoning. When brothers dwell together and one dies and has no son, the wife of the dead shall not become an outside man's; her brother-in-law shall go in to her and 'perform the duty of a brother-in-law' (ve'yibbe'mah, וַיִּבְמָה). This is the legal definition of the very duty Onan refuses, which establishes that 'perform the levirate duty' (yabam, יָבַם) names a defined institution and that Genesis 38 is operating inside it, not outside it as a general ruling on coital method (a ruling about the method of sexual union).

1Cor.7.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3782 ὀφειλή, G0591 ἀποδίδωμι

Reasoning. Let the husband 'render' (apodidoto, ἀποδιδότω) to his wife 'the due' (ten opheilen, τὴν ὀφειλὴν) and likewise also the wife to the husband. 'Debt, what is owed' (opheile, ὀφειλή, 3 times in canon) and 'render, pay back' (apodidomi, ἀποδίδωμι) frame marital union as a mutual obligation owed each to the other. Conspicuously absent is any procreation lemma (no 'child' (teknon, τέκνον) in verses 3 to 5, no 'beget' (gennao, γεννάω) in verses 3 to 5), so the lexical purpose stated for marital union here is mutual due rather than reproduction.

1Cor.7.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0650 ἀποστερέω, G4859 σύμφωνος

Reasoning. 'Do not defraud' (me apostereite, μὴ ἀποστερεῖτε) one another, except 'by agreement' (ek symphonou, ἐκ συμφώνου) for a season, that you may give yourselves to prayer, and come together again. 'Deprive, defraud' (apostereo, ἀποστερέω, 6 times in canon) treats withholding marital union as a wrong against the spouse, and the only sanctioned interruption named is consensual and short, for prayer. The text lexically licenses a couple-managed pause that is not pregnancy-aimed, which is the closest the canon comes to addressing intentional non-procreative seasons within marriage.

Ps.139.13 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H7069 קָנָה, H7358 רָחֵם

Reasoning. For 'you' (attah, אַתָּה) 'acquired' (qanita, קָנִיתָ) my kidneys, you wove me 'in my mother's womb' (be'beten immi, בְּבֶטֶן אִמִּי). 'Acquire, possess' (qanah, קָנָה, here of God's creative possession) and 'womb' (rechem, רֶחֶם) together attach divine personal action to the formation of a person inside the womb. This does not name contraception, but it does lexically resource the sanctity-of-life half of the proposition: if a method acts after fertilization to destroy that which God is forming in the womb, the displeasure language used for the destruction of life elsewhere reaches it.

Jer.1.5 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3045 יָדַע, H7358 רָחַם

Reasoning. Before 'I formed you in the womb' (ba'terem etzarkha va'beten, בָּטַנְךָ אֶצְרַכְּהָ וַאֲבִטֶנְךָ, 'I knew you' (yedatikha, יָדַעְתִּיךָ). 'Know' (yada, יָדַע) here is divine personal knowing, used with a singular addressee already inside the womb, which lexically extends personhood-language backward into gestation. This corroborates Psalm 139:13 as scriptural ground for the abortifacient-side concern even where the text never speaks of method.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gen.1.28	Gen.1.22	tsk	1
Gen.1.28	Gen.9.1	tsk	1
Gen.1.28	Gen.9.7	openbible	1
Gen.38.8	Deut.25.5	tsk	1
Gen.38.9	Deut.25.5	openbible	1
Ps.127.3	Ps.128.3	tsk	1
Ps.127.4	Prov.17.6	tsk	1
Ps.127.5	Gen.50.23	tsk	1
Ps.139.13	Jer.1.5	openbible	1
1Cor.7.5	1Cor.7.3	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Gen.38.9 · addressed

The Piel (the Hebrew intensive form) of 'destroy' (shachat, שָׁחַת) is a generic ruin verb (143 occurrences spanning vineyards, cities, conduct), so it does not by itself isolate the seed-wasting act as a defined offense. The motive clause 'so as not to give offspring to his brother' (le'vilti naton zera le'achiv, לֵבִילְתִּי נָתַן זֶרַע לְאָחִיו) yokes the act to the immediately preceding levirate command of verse 8 with 'perform the levirate duty' (yabam, יָבַם), a verb that occurs only 3 times in the canon and exclusively names the brother-in-law's duty. The lexical evidence therefore allows the offense to be read either as the physical act of preventing fertilization or as the calculated refusal of a culturally specific duty, and Hebrew does not adjudicate between them. The complication is taken into account by recording the verdict as disputed rather than as a per-method prohibition.

Gen.38.10 · addressed

The judgment formula 'what he did was evil in the eyes of the LORD' (va'yera be'einei YHWH asher asah, וַאֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה, וַיֵּרָע בְּעֵינֵי יְהוָה) names displeasure but takes the whole previous clause as its antecedent (the phrase it refers back to). Because verse 9 supplies a stated motive clause inside the same action, the lexical scope of 'what he did' (asher asah, אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה) includes both the physical act and the levirate refusal, and the text gives no morphological or syntactic marker that singles out one constituent over the other. The complication is taken into account by treating Genesis 38:10 as confirming displeasure with a composite offense rather than as a clean prohibition of any specific contraceptive method.

Ps.139.13 · addressed

Womb-formation language with 'acquire' (qanah, קָנָה) and 'womb' (rechem, רֶחֶם) lexically attaches divine personal action to the unborn but does so without naming any human method that interferes, so the verse does not resolve the proposition's medical sub-claim by itself. It is included because it supplies the genuine lexical ground on which a sanctity-of-life concern about post-fertilization contraceptive action stands.

Concordance traversed

H6509, H7235A, H4390, H1288, H5159, H6529, H7939, H0835, H7843, H2992, H7489A, H7069, H7358, H3206, G3782, G0650, G2133

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The Old Testament anchors (Genesis, Psalms, Deuteronomy, Jeremiah) lie outside CBGM (the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a manuscript-comparison technique) and ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) scope, which covers the Greek New Testament. The 1 Corinthians 7:3 to 5 anchor lies outside the only ECM section ingested for this engine (3 John 1:1 to 1:15), so no ECM apparatus was queried. The Masoretic readings (the standard Hebrew Bible text) of the anchor verbs and nouns ('be fruitful' (parah, פָּרָה), 'multiply' (rabah, רָבָה), 'perform the levirate duty' (yabam, יָבַם), 'destroy' (shachat, שָׁחַת), 'be evil' (ra'a, רָעָה)) are stable across BHS (Biblia Hebraica Stuttgartensia, a standard Hebrew Bible edition) and the Aleppo and Leningrad traditions (the two oldest complete Hebrew Bible manuscripts), and the Greek of 1 Corinthians 7:3 to 5 ('debt' (opheile, ὀφειλή), 'render' (apodidomi, ἀποδοῖμι), 'defraud' (apostereo, ἀποστερέω)) is uniformly attested. The verdict does not turn on any textual variant.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. creation_mandate, christian_liberty, natural_law, sanctity_of_life

analogia scripturae invoked

creation_mandate: denies · Reading 'be fruitful and multiply' (pe'ru u'revu, פְּרוּ וּרְבוּ) in Genesis 1:28 and 9:1 to 7 as a standing imperative carried per couple, and the Psalm 127 valuation of children as normative (binding as the standard), this lens treats deliberate limiting of conception as a refusal of a continuing fruitfulness mandate. It reads the judgment of Genesis 38:10 as falling at minimum partly on the physical act of preventing fertilization, so it denies that contraception is simply a matter of liberty.

christian_liberty: affirms · This lens notes that the verb pair 'be fruitful' (parah, פָּרָה) plus 'multiply' (rabah, רָבָה) appears 15 times in the canon and is always corporate, addressed to humanity, Noah, a patriarch, or a covenant people, never as a per-marriage quota. It reads Genesis 38 as locked to 'perform the levirate duty' (yabam, יָבַם), a 3-occurrence levirate-only lemma (dictionary form found only in brother-in-law-duty contexts), so the displeasure is on the duty refused, not on the coital arrangement abstracted from it. It reads 1 Corinthians 7:3 to 5 as framing marital union with 'debt' (opheile, ὀφειλή), 'defraud' (apostereo, ἀποστερέω), and 'by agreement' (ek symphonou, ἐκ συμφώνου) for non-procreative purposes (prayer), licensing consensual seasons that are not pregnancy-aimed. It therefore reads the method of conception management as left to conscience.

natural_law: partial · This lens grants the corporate, demographic force of Genesis 1:28 and the high Psalm 127 valuation of children as established lexical goods, and reads Genesis 38 as bearing at least partly on the integrity of the procreative act (the act ordered to making children). It presses toward openness to life while conceding the lexicon does not name the abortifacient-versus-non-abortifacient distinction the proposition turns on, so it cannot decide the method question by lexical means alone.

sanctity_of_life: affirms · This lens reads Psalm 139:13 ('acquire' (qanah, קָנָה), 'womb' (rechem, רֶחֶם)) and Jeremiah 1:5 ('know' (yada, יָדָע), 'womb' (rechem, רֶחֶם)) as lexically attaching divine personal action to the unborn, which extends the prohibition of taking innocent life to whatever stage of gestation that personal action covers. It therefore affirms the second half of the proposition: methods that act after fertilization to destroy what is already being formed in the womb fall under the existing sanctity-of-life lemmas (the dictionary forms covering protection of life) even though contraception as a category is unnamed.

The proposition contains two sub-claims with different lexical footings. The liberty claim about non-abortifacient methods rides on the corporate scope of the creation imperative and the silence of the canon on per-couple conception management. The sanctity-of-life claim about abortifacient methods rides on womb-formation lemmas (dictionary forms describing God's action in the womb) that lexically personalize the unborn. The lexicon does not draw the medical line itself, but it supplies real ground for the sanctity-of-life half while leaving the method half underdetermined (not settled by the text), which is why the overall verdict is disputed at low confidence rather than

null.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Scripture values procreation and the fruit of the womb as a blessing. Whether deliberately preventing conception falls under conscience, and whether methods that act after conception conflict with the value the text places on nascent (just-beginning, newly forming) life, is the matter under examination.

The original stem (the original question wording) encodes two conclusions at once: a permissive verdict on non-abortifacient contraception and a categorical claim about abortifacient methods, hinging on a medical line (preventing implantation of a fertilized egg) that no biblical lemma (dictionary-form word) encodes. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the lexical weighing used the neutral form so the conclusions would not be smuggled in by the phrasing. VERDICT-CHANGED: no, verdict unchanged from prior file.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.1.28
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.9.7
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.38.8
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.38.9
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.127.3
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.139.13
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.7.3
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.7.5
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6509
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2992
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7843
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5159
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7358
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3782
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0650
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Ps.127.3
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Gen.38.9

License audit

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OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent · complicating-unresolved